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To a Cheerful 'Man of Letters' The Dictionary Is an Art Form

Never let it be said that Philippe Maucotel is a man of few words.

"I am," he explains, laughing, "a man of letters."

He has done something particular with those letters. He has shaped them into words of wood, into syllables of cement and into *mots* of metal. Maucotel, man of letters, thus has become a man of sculpture.

And now, he wants people to get their words' worth.

He invites a visitor to step into the Palm Gallery at 408 Atlantic Ave., where an exhibit of his words and their works will open tomorrow. And smiling broadly, chuckling softly, Maucotel shares a few of his choicest words.

"Train of Thoughts," say some of those words, in carved wooden script he has placed atop the movable wheels of a model train. "Autosatisfaction," says another string of cursive letters, riding the top of a racy green model sportscar. "Hangover," bleats a particularly woeful item on display, as it bends over, and splits into a double image.

It is all a game of semantics, or "Cementics," as Maucotel has titled his exhibit. In fact, the title piece, formed in cement, spells out the title word, and sits prominently in the back of the gallery, as one of 29 words on display.

"I want to have fun," Maucotel says. "I do have fun."

In fact, he explains somewhat dubiously, there is a reason he moved his Suffolk County studio from Southold to Cutchogue. "I couldn't say the 'h' in Southold," he says, wryly. "And because I cut wood, I belonged in Cutchogue."

His obvious gamepiece is the English language, which is not his native tongue, but which he has loved, fluently, for most of his life. In many pieces on display, he has carved his words out of wood using only a jigsaw, presumably one as sharp as his own wit.

"Maucotel," he explains, "translates to 'bad blade.'" That's one fact he seems to enjoy, thoroughly.

The 45-year-old Cobble Hill resident is a French teacher at a Brooklyn private school. Before he left France, more than 20 years ago, he taught French there, too. He was also a poet.

To Maucotel, then, words say very much, whether written or spoken. And so he has dedicated the exhibit in memory of Oscar Schloss, a friend of his from Southold who died on March 2. Maucotel said the ailing Schloss had chosen chemotherapy rather than larynx surgery, "because he wanted to go on speaking. And that may have cost him his life." He said Schloss, a former broadcast executive, had shared Maucotel's love of words as well as good conversation and laughter. "He was a good friend," said Maucotel. And suddenly, this man of words can no longer find the right ones to say.

—Caryn Eve Wiener